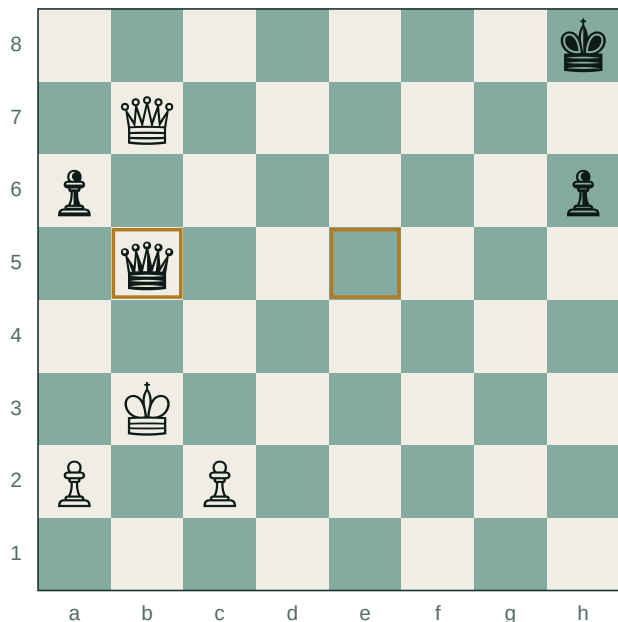


Queen-ending tactics: White, move 37

Queen-ending tactics

White to move



Previous move: 36...Qb5+. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

37. Qxb5 axb5 38. c4 bxc4+ 39. Kxc4

37.Qxb5 The queen captures the queen on b5. Recorded reply: **37...axb5**.

38.c4 The pawn moves from c2 to c4. Recorded reply: **38...bxc4+**.

39.Kxc4 The king captures the pawn on c4.

At the end, nominal material is White 1 / Black 1 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +0. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +0: the balance goes from +0 to +0. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A favorable-looking queen exchange can lead to a drawn pawn ending. Evaluate the new ending before simplifying.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Queens combine long-range checks with promotion support. King shelter and the order of checks often matter more than a small material lead.

HOW TO LOOK

Inspect perpetual-check possibilities, queen trades, and checks that gain a tempo for a passed pawn.

The defending king is on h8. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.